

Vaccine Misinformation and Anti-Vaccine Campaigns

Documented organizations, funding relationships, narratives, and political activity

Research table – United States and Europe

Scope and evidentiary conventions

This table maps organizations and funding relationships documented in publicly available tax records, audited financial statements, investigative reporting, and European or U.S. institutional investigations. It does *not* assume that every statement made by an organization listed here is false, nor that the existence of a funding relationship proves that a donor directed the recipient’s scientific or political positions.

The terms “misinformation”, “vaccine-skeptical”, and “anti-vaccine” are used descriptively and are attributed to the cited investigations where appropriate. Claim-level scientific assessment should be performed separately for particular claims. Funding amounts are time-specific and should not be extrapolated to the present without checking newer filings.

Organization / actor	Region	Role	Documented funding / finance	Funders / funding evidence	Vaccine misinformation or policy activity	European / political dimension	Evidence strength
Children's Health Defense (CHD)	USA / Europe	Anti-vaccine advocacy, media, litigation and political mobilization	2022 revenue \$23.54m; 95.8% contributions; 2020 revenue \$6.83m	Donor identities are not fully visible in the summary financial data. Historical leadership/funding ecosystem includes Robert F. Kennedy Jr.; CHD has also sponsored/participated in European activity.	Promoted or amplified claims alleging serious vaccine harms and opposing mandates; specific claims should be checked individually rather than treating all CHD output as false.	EU DisinfoLab documented a Belgian structure from 2020 and lobbying/events aimed at European institutions.	High for financial totals; high for European expansion; claim-level assessment requires separate sourcing.
Informed Consent Action Network (ICAN)	USA	Litigation, FOIA requests, media and anti-mandate advocacy	Selz Foundation gave \$100,000 in 2016 (83% of funding) and >\$1m in 2017 (74% of revenue); revenue about \$13.4m in 2022	Bernard and Lisa Selz / Selz Foundation are documented major funders in the cited period.	Vaccine-safety and mandate claims; litigation often challenged government vaccine-safety information or requirements. Individual claims should be assessed separately.	Major U.S. organizational node; AP later identified its leaders/associates in the broader health-freedom political network.	High for historical Selz funding; high for 2022 revenue; claim-level assessment varies.
National Vaccine Information Center (NVIC)	USA	Long-running vaccine-opposition advocacy, legislation tracking, lobbying	FY2024 Mercola donations \$400,749 = 22% of total revenue	Mercola.com / Natural Health Research Foundation: >\$2.9m historically; FY2024 audited statement reports \$400,749.	Opposes or seeks limits on vaccine mandates; publishes vaccine-risk narratives. The organization's policy positions should be distinguished from demonstrably false medical claims.	AP identified NVIC as one of four national groups supporting many 2025 anti-vaccine state bills.	High for FY2024 donor amount; high for historical Mercola relationship.

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Joseph Mercola / Mercola.com	USA / transnational	Commercial alternative-health media and products; major donor to vaccine-opposition organizations	Natural Health Research Foundation gave >\$2.9m to NVIC over the decade examined by Washington Post; >\$3.3m to Organic Consumers Association in that report.	Joseph Mercola and his foundation are the documented funders.	Mercola.com has promoted vaccine skepticism and claims presenting supplements as alternatives to vaccination; regulators have separately challenged some non-vaccine health claims.	Acts as a funding and media node rather than simply an advocacy nonprofit.	High for funding amounts reported from tax records; claim-specific evidence should be cited separately.
Selz Foundation / Bernard & Lisa Selz	USA	Philanthropic funding of anti-vaccine advocacy/media	>\$3m to anti-vaccine groups in the Washington Post's 2019 investigation; \$200,000 to an Andrew Wakefield legal fund in 2012	Bernard and Lisa Selz / their foundation.	Funding supported projects and organizations promoting vaccine-skeptical narratives; funding itself does not prove that every claim made by recipients was false.	Important example of concentrated private philanthropic support.	High for documented grants in the cited period.
World Mercury Project (later part of CHD)	USA	Online advertising and vaccine-skeptic messaging	A 2019 study reported that World Mercury Project and Stop Mandatory Vaccinations together accounted for 54% of anti-vaccine Facebook ads in the study sample.	Campaign funding attribution is based on the advertising study; this row does not infer the ultimate source of all funds.	Facebook ads promoted vaccine-skeptic messages; study focused on advertising prevalence rather than adjudicating every claim.	Later incorporated into/associated with CHD.	High for the cited advertising-study finding; not evidence of all online misinformation.

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Stop Mandatory Vaccinations / Larry Cook	USA	Grassroots-style online mobilization and advertising	Same 2019 advertising study: together with World Mercury Project, 54% of sampled anti-vaccine Facebook ads.	Ultimate funders not established by that statistic.	Anti-mandate and vaccine-skeptic messaging.	Useful example of social-media amplification without assuming a centralized funding source.	High for advertising share in the cited sample; funding attribution limited.
MAHA Action	USA	State-level political mobilization around Make America Healthy Again priorities	AP 2025 identified it as one of four national groups supporting many anti-vaccine bills; no single donor amount is asserted here.	AP reported leadership connections including Tony Lyons and Del Bigtree.	Supported legislation challenging vaccine requirements and other public-health measures.	Part of a newer political layer connecting health-freedom activism with state legislation.	High for AP-documented political activity; funding amounts not established in this table.
Stand for Health Freedom	USA	Advocacy, alerts, grassroots mobilization and legislation	No single donor amount asserted here; AP documented its participation in the 2025 state legislative campaign.	Co-founded by Sayer Ji; AP reported links with MAHA Action.	Supports vaccine exemptions/mandate restrictions and broader health-freedom positions.	Works across states through alerts, calls and legislative mobilization.	High for documented political activity; funding amounts not established here.
Weston A. Price Foundation	USA / international audience	Alternative-health advocacy; raw milk and health-freedom campaigns; vaccine-related activism	No single donor amount asserted here.	AP documented collaboration with NVIC and Stand for Health Freedom on a 2025 letter.	Publishes claims about raw milk and health; AP noted that its site contains unproven claims about raw milk treating conditions. Vaccine-related positions should be assessed separately.	Part of the broader health-freedom ecosystem rather than solely a vaccine organization.	High for AP-documented collaboration; claim-level evidence varies.

Organization / actor	Region	Role	Documented funding / finance	Funders / funding evidence	Vaccine misinformation or policy activity	European / political dimension	Evidence strength
Children's Health Defense Europe	EU / Belgium	European expansion of U.S. vaccine-opposition network; events and lobbying	EU DisinfoLab reports a Belgian legal structure established from August 2020; no donor amount asserted here.	Parent organization is CHD; the study documents organizational expansion rather than a complete European donor ledger.	Spread vaccine-skeptical narratives and pursued lobbying/events directed toward the European Parliament.	Documented transatlantic organizational expansion.	High for organizational facts in EU DisinfoLab report; funding source details limited.
European vaccine-misinformation ecosystem (multi-actor)	EU/EEA	Decentralized online misinformation and amplification	No single funding source can responsibly be assigned to the ecosystem as a whole.	ECDC's 2021 study identified multiple sources and mechanisms across Estonia, France, Germany, Netherlands, Spain and Romania.	False or misleading claims about vaccine harms, COVID-19, MMR, HPV and influenza were documented as recurring themes.	ECDC emphasizes that misinformation sources are heterogeneous; this is not evidence of a single centralized European sponsor.	High for existence/heterogeneity; not a funding attribution.

Principal sources

1. Associated Press, 2025: *Anti-science bills hit statehouses, stripping away public health protections built over a century..* <https://www.ap.org/news-highlights/spotlights/2025/anti-science-bills-hit-statehouses>
2. ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer, CHD: *Children’s Health Defense financial data from Form 990..* <https://projects.propublica.org/nonprofits/organizations/260388604>
3. Washington Post, 2024: *Tax records reveal the lucrative world of covid misinformation..* <https://www.washingtonpost.com/nation/2024/02/21/covid-misinformation-earnings/>
4. Washington Post, 2019: *Meet the New York couple donating millions to the anti-vax movement..* https://www.washingtonpost.com/national/health-science/meet-the-new-york-couple-donating-millions-to-2019/06/18/9d791bcc-8e28-11e9-b5e4-54aa56d5b7ce_story.html
5. Washington Post, 2019: *A major funder of the anti-vaccine movement has made millions selling natural health products..* https://www.washingtonpost.com/investigations/2019/10/15/fdc01078-c29c-11e9-b5e4-54aa56d5b7ce_story.html
6. NVIC, FY2024 audited financial statements: *Audited financial statement documenting Mercola donations of \$400,749, 22% of FY2024 revenue..* <https://www.nvic.org/getmedia/9a8911e2-57a9-40aa-8a6b-ffeb82d006f1/FYE-2024-Audit-Report-24.pdf>
7. EU DisinfoLab, 2023: *The US anti-vax group Children’s Health Defense’s expansion to Europe..* <https://www.disinfo.eu/publications/the-us-anti-vax-group-childrens-health-defenses-expansion-to-europe>
8. ECDC, 2021: *Countering online vaccine misinformation in the EU/EEA..* <https://www.ecdc.europa.eu/en/publications-data/countering-online-vaccine-misinformation-eu-eea>

Interpretive notes

1. The clearest documented financial relationships in this table are the Selz Foundation’s historical support of ICAN and projects associated with Andrew Wakefield, Joseph Mercola’s historical and FY2024 support of NVIC, and the large contribution base reported by Children’s Health Defense.
2. The European evidence is strongest for organizational expansion and lobbying: EU DisinfoLab documented CHD’s Belgian structure, events, and engagement with the European Parliament. This should not be converted into a claim that all European vaccine misinformation is centrally controlled from the United States.
3. The 2025 Associated Press investigation documents a newer political layer in which MAHA Action, Stand for Health Freedom, NVIC, and the Weston A. Price Foundation supported or opposed state legislation. This is evidence of political mobilization, not by itself evidence about the truth or falsity of every medical claim made by those organizations.
4. ECDC’s EU/EEA review emphasizes that vaccine misinformation has heterogeneous sources and mechanisms. Consequently, a responsible research project should avoid assigning a single “sponsor” to the entire European misinformation ecosystem.